

A FIELD MANUAL

# FIT AS RUCK

**8-WEEK  
TRAINING**

• **HYBRID  
PROGRAM**

**THE PREMISE** *Ruck, lift, and one tactical finisher a week — programmed around the recovery reality of a forty-something body. Not event prep. Not selection-candidate volume. A real comeback.*

BY

**MJ**

RUCKTALK · 2026

FITASRUCK.COM

**\$29 · ONE-TIME**

# FIT AS RUCK

## THE 8-WEEK HYBRID TRAINING PLAN FOR MEN OVER 35 WHO ARE DONE SCREWING AROUND

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By **MJ** Host of RuckTalk | Ground Rush Inc.

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For the guys who used to know what they were doing, and are ready to know again.

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## HOW TO USE THIS PROGRAM

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This is not a book you read once and put on a shelf. It's a program. Weeks 1 and 2 are your on-ramp. Do not skip them because they feel easy. They are designed to feel manageable — that's the whole point. By Week 6 you will understand why.

Read the chapter that applies to your current week before you start that week. Keep the logbook pages at the back. Track your loads, your distances, and your sleep. The data is what tells you whether to push or pull back — and at our age, that information matters.

If you miss a day, move on. This program is not going to punish you for being a dad, having a job, or being a human being. Just don't make missing a habit.

One thing I will ask: don't skip straight to Week 8. The Fit as Ruck Finisher is earned, not gifted.

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# CHAPTER 1

## WHY YOU'RE HERE: THE COMEBACK PREMISE

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I'm going to start with honesty, because that's the only way this is useful to you.

The moment I knew I had to come back was when I realized I had slowly picked up too many bad habits. My sleep was terrible, I was drinking, and I had even started smoking cigarettes. Yeah, I know, don't judge me. Then one day I woke up after only about an hour of sleep, and I felt like my heart was all over the place. I could barely breathe, and I was having a full-blown panic attack. In that moment, I knew I had changed, and not in a good way. I knew I had to make a complete 180 if I really wanted to enjoy my life again.

That's where this program was born. Not in a gym. Not from a coaching certification. It came from a 3am moment where I had to decide who I was going to be.

If you're reading this, something similar probably happened to you. Maybe not that dramatic — maybe you just looked in the mirror one morning and didn't recognize yourself. Maybe you got winded doing something that used to be nothing. Maybe a doctor said something you didn't want to hear. Maybe you just looked at photos from five years ago and thought, where did that guy go?

I wrote this because staying fit means more to me than just working out. It's about discipline, strength, energy, and being able to show up at a high level in every part of life. And if something has helped me become better, sharper, and more in control, I naturally want the people around me to benefit from it too.

That's not a manifesto. That's just how I think.

Here's what this program is: an 8-week hybrid plan that combines rucking, functional strength, and tactical conditioning, built around the recovery reality of a man over 35. You're going to carry weight, lift weight, and do some things that will kick your ass. But nothing here is designed to wreck you. Nothing here is event prep or selection volume. This is not a military training plan. This is a coming-back-strong plan for guys who have real lives and real responsibilities and still want to be physically capable and sharp.

Here's what it is not: HIIT every day. Cardio-only fluff. A program built for a 22-year-old who has 3 hours to train and no recovery debt. Whatever fasting-and-cold-plunge content you saw last week that made you feel like you're behind — none of that is here.

What you will find here is rucking as the backbone. If you don't know what rucking is: you put weight in a pack or vest, and you walk. That's it. But what happens to your body when you do it consistently, loaded progressively, combined with strength work — that's where the results are. My buddy Jason and I have been doing ruck hikes together, and I will tell you straight: there is no easier on the joints, more effective for cardiovascular fitness, and more mentally clarifying training modality I've found at this age. You can go on a long walk, or you can make it aggressive — a four-mile loop, repeat it three or four rounds, throw in exercises. You can make it what you want.

You're not a beginner. You're a returner. That's different. You have the body awareness, you know what pain is informational versus what pain is injury, you know how to push. You just need a structure that doesn't assume you're 22 anymore.

Eight weeks. Let's go.

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# CHAPTER 2

## THE SCIENCE, BRIEFLY

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I'm not going to write you a textbook. But I want you to understand why this program is structured the way it is, because when you understand the why, you don't skip the parts that seem boring.

Three researchers have shaped how I think about training at this age. I'm going to give you the short version of each one, and then we're done with the science.

### **Peter Attia and Zone 2**

Peter Attia is a physician and longevity researcher who has done more to popularize the concept of Zone 2 cardio than anyone else in the last ten years. Zone 2 means low-intensity aerobic work — roughly 60-70% of your max heart rate, the zone where you can hold a conversation but wouldn't want to. Nasal breathing is a good proxy: if you have to open your mouth, you've left Zone 2.

Why does it matter? Because Zone 2 is where mitochondrial density increases. Your cells' ability to produce energy improves. Your fat-burning efficiency improves. Your aerobic base — which is the foundation that everything else sits on — gets built here. Attia talks about the "Centenarian Decathlon," the idea that you should be training today for the physical capacity you want at 85. Carrying groceries. Getting off the floor. Walking without a cane.

Rucking at the right pace is Zone 2. That's not an accident. Weeks 1-3 of this program are almost entirely Zone 2 work, and I want you to stay there. Don't try to turn every ruck into a race. The slow work is where the engine gets built.

### **Michael Easter and Why We Carry Load**

Michael Easter wrote *The Comfort Crisis*, and one of the things he spent a lot of time on is the evolutionary argument for load carriage. Humans are built for it. For most of human history, we moved on foot and we carried things. Heavy things. Over long distances. Our skeletal structure, our posterior chain, our cardiovascular system — all of it was shaped by that demand.

When you ruck, you're not doing something exotic. You're doing something your body recognizes at a cellular level. Easter documented research showing that load carriage activates muscle groups that ordinary walking and running don't touch. It builds bone density. It builds the posterior chain. And it does all of this with dramatically lower joint impact than running.

That last part matters more at 40 than it did at 25. Running at high volume breaks guys our age down. Rucking builds them up.

### **Stuart Phillips and Protein**

Dr. Stuart Phillips at McMaster University has done extensive research on protein synthesis and muscle mass preservation. The headline finding relevant to us: men over 35 need approximately 1.6 grams of protein per kilogram of bodyweight per day to support muscle protein synthesis under training load. In practical terms, if you weigh 200 pounds (about 90 kg), that's around 144 grams of protein a day. Most guys are nowhere near that.

This is not bro-science. This is peer-reviewed research, and it directly applies to why men in their 40s and 50s lose muscle mass faster than they expect. Sarcopenia — muscle loss with age — starts around 35 and accelerates if you're under-eating protein and not providing the stimulus to maintain muscle. This program provides the stimulus. Chapter 5 covers the protein.

### **Progressive Load — Why You Start at 20 Pounds**

The single most common mistake I see men our age make when they come back to training is going too hard too fast. They did a program at 28, they remember what they could do at 28, and they try to start there. That's how you get hurt and quit by Week 2.

The program starts at 20 pounds in your ruck. That probably feels light to you. That's fine. The load is not the point in Week 1. The movement pattern, the cumulative fatigue over distance, and the foundation for the 6-week progression that follows — that's the point. By Week 6, when you're at 35-40 pounds for a 6-mile ruck, you'll understand why we started slow.

Recovery time at 40 is not what it was at 25. Your body needs 48-72 hours between hard sessions. This program builds that in. Don't freelance around it.

# CHAPTER 3

## GEAR CHECKLIST

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Let's keep this practical. You don't need to spend \$500 before you start. You need a way to carry weight, something to wear on your feet, and access to some weights. That's it.

### THE RUCK

A rucksack with a way to add weight plates. The GORUCK GR1 and Rucker are built specifically for this, and if you can afford one, they're worth it — they're structured, they distribute weight well, and they'll outlast you. The 5.11 Rush 24 is a solid mid-range option that holds its shape under load. If budget is a constraint, a decent tactical backpack plus a set of ruck plates from Amazon will get you started. What you want to avoid is a bag that compresses and shifts weight away from your back — the load should ride high and tight, close to your spine.

Weight plates made for rucksacks are flat and slip into the main pocket without shifting. Standard gym plates work in a pinch but are clunky. Dedicated ruck plates are worth the \$30-40.

Weeks 1-2: 20 lb. Weeks 3-5: 25-35 lb. Weeks 6-7: 35-40 lb. Week 8 Finisher: 35 lb.

Don't load up past what the program calls for. Your ego is not part of the training prescription.

### THE WEIGHTED VEST

Here's something most rucking programs miss: a weighted vest is a co-equal training tool, not a secondary option. Some days you want the vest over the pack — especially for push-ups, pull-ups, carries, or when you're doing hill repeats and don't want the ruck to shift around.

One piece of gear I use and genuinely love is my weighted vest from GRAVGEAR. It sits high on my body, has a ton of padding across the shoulders, and feels secure without dragging me down. You can load it up to 37 pounds total, with up to 30 pounds in added 5-pound weights, and the vest itself weighs about 7 pounds. What I like most is how balanced it feels when I

train in it. Whether I'm doing rucks, push-ups, or pull-ups, it stays close to my body and still gives me plenty of breathing room. It does not feel sloppy or uncomfortable. It feels supportive, solid, and built for real work. Another reason I like it so much is because it is versatile. You can attach chains to it and use it for things like sled drags, which gives you even more ways to train. Out of all the gear I've bought, this has easily been one of the best purchases I've made.

I'm not telling you to go buy a GRAVGEAR vest. I'm telling you what I use and what works for me. If you have a different vest that fits well and loads evenly, use it. The important thing is that you have a vest option in addition to a pack, because some of the best training in this program — especially the finishers and calisthenics sets — work better in a vest than in a ruck.

## FOOTWEAR

Here's my honest take: both boots and trail runners work. Don't let anyone tell you one is mandatory.

Boots give you ankle stability, which matters on uneven terrain and at heavier loads. If you're doing off-road ruck hikes over rough ground, I'd rather have a boot on. The tradeoff is break-in time — a new pair of boots at 30 pounds will eat your feet if you don't put some miles on them first.

Trail runners are lighter, more versatile, and need no break-in time. At 20-25 pounds, they're completely adequate. I've done plenty of rucks in trail runners. At 35+ pounds on rough terrain, I reach for boots.

My recommendation: use what you have and already know fits you. Blisters are the enemy of consistency in this program. Worn-in footwear beats optimal footwear every time.

## OPTIONAL BUT USEFUL

**Heart rate monitor.** If you want to train Zone 2 with precision, a chest strap HR monitor is the most accurate way. A Garmin, Coros, or any GPS watch with HR works for distance. These aren't required — pace and perceived exertion work fine — but if you're a data person, they're worth having.



**Foam roller.** Not optional for me at 53. After every strength day, 5-10 minutes on the quads, IT band, lats, and thoracic spine. It takes a few weeks before you feel the difference and then you won't skip it.

**Kettlebell.** For the tactical finishers and goblet squats in this program, you need at least one kettlebell. A 35-44 lb bell covers most of what this program calls for. If you have two different weights (say, 26 and 44 lb), you're fully equipped.

**Sandbag.** The Fit as Ruck Finisher includes sandbag shoulders. A 40-50 lb sandbag is sufficient. Rogue, Brute Force, or fill a duffel bag with sand and duct-tape the hell out of it. The last option works fine.

That's the list. Total investment if you're starting from scratch: ruck (\$50-\$200), plates (\$30-\$60), one kettlebell (\$40-\$80), vest (\$100-\$200 if you go GRAVGEAR), footwear (what you have). Under \$300 for the full setup if you're budget-conscious. This is not CrossFit. You don't need a gym membership.

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# CHAPTER 4

## THE 8-WEEK PROGRAM

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A few rules before we start:

**Rule 1:** If your sleep was under 6 hours, reduce intensity by 30%. Don't skip, but don't try to hit numbers your body can't support.

**Rule 2:** The notation "AMRAP" means As Many Reps As Possible with good form. Not sloppy form. If your form breaks, stop the set.

**Rule 3:** Rest days are training. They are where adaptation happens. Don't fill them with "active recovery" that turns into a second hard session.

**Rule 4:** Tempo rucks are brisk — uncomfortable but sustainable. You should NOT be able to hold a full conversation. Zone 2 rucks are conversational. Know the difference.

**Rule 5:** When the program says 40+ modification, that means: if you're over 40 and feeling beat up, use the modification. It's not the easy way out. It's how you stay in the program for 8 weeks instead of 3.

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## WEEKS 1-2: BASELINE + MOVEMENT PREP

You're building the foundation. Not the house. Don't rush this.

The goal of Weeks 1-2 is to establish your Zone 2 ruck pace, get your body used to carrying load, and find out where your weak links are. Hip flexors? Ankles? Lower back? These two weeks tell you things you need to know.

### Common mistakes in Weeks 1-2:

"Loading too much, too fast. I see guys start at 40 pounds because they're embarrassed by 20. By Day 10 they've got shin splints and a pissed-off lower back. Start at 20. I mean it."

"Skipping the mobility work. The 10 minutes of hip/ankle/T-spine work each day is not warm-up fluff. It's what keeps your joints healthy under load for 8 weeks."

**End of Week 2 Baseline Test:** Timed 3-mile ruck at 20 lb. Write down your time. You'll retest this at Week 8.

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### Week 1

| Day    | Session          | Details                                                      |
|--------|------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| Monday | Ruck —<br>Zone 2 | 2 miles @ 20 lb. Nasal breathing throughout. Note your pace. |

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| Day       | Session                  | Details                                                                                                                        |
|-----------|--------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Tuesday   | <b>Strength A</b>        | 3×10 goblet squat (light KB), 3×10 RDL, 3×10 push-ups, 3×10 DB row each side, 3×10 farmer carry (40m). Rest 90s between sets.  |
| Wednesday | <b>Mobility + Rest</b>   | 10 min: hip flexor stretch, ankle circles, cat-cow, thoracic rotation. Walk 20 min easy if you want.                           |
| Thursday  | <b>Ruck — Zone 2</b>     | 2 miles @ 20 lb. Same pace target as Monday.                                                                                   |
| Friday    | <b>Strength B</b>        | 3×10 KB deadlift or trap bar, 3×10 overhead press (DB or KB), 3×8 pull-ups or ring rows, 3×12 KB swings, 2×40m weighted carry. |
| Saturday  | <b>Tactical Finisher</b> | 3 rounds: 10 push-ups, 10 goblet squats, 10 KB swings, 200m run or fast walk. Rest 2 min between rounds.                       |
| Sunday    | <b>Full Rest</b>         | No training. Eat well. Sleep.                                                                                                  |

**40+ Modification:** If Week 1 Day 1 leaves you sore for 3 days, your baseline is lower than you thought. Drop to 15 lb on the ruck and 2 sets on strength work for the rest of the week. No shame in that.

**Recovery Check-in:** Rate your sleep quality 1-10 and your energy levels 1-10 each day. If both stay below 6 for more than 3 days in a row, add a rest day.

## Week 2

| Day       | Session                | Details                                                                                                |
|-----------|------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Monday    | <b>Ruck — Zone 2</b>   | 2.5 miles @ 20 lb. Same nasal-breathing pace.                                                          |
| Tuesday   | <b>Strength A</b>      | 3×12 goblet squat, 3×10 RDL (increase weight slightly), 3×12 push-ups, 3×10 DB row, 3×10 farmer carry. |
| Wednesday | <b>Mobility + Rest</b> | 10 min: same as Week 1. Add glute bridge 2×15.                                                         |
| Thursday  | <b>Ruck — Zone 2</b>   | 2.5 miles @ 20 lb.                                                                                     |

| Day      | Session              | Details                                                                                          |
|----------|----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Friday   | <b>Strength B</b>    | 3×10 trap bar or KB deadlift, 3×10 OHP, 3×10 pull-ups or ring rows, 3×15 KB swings, 2×40m carry. |
| Saturday | <b>Baseline Test</b> | Timed 3-mile ruck @ 20 lb. Record your time. This is your benchmark.                             |
| Sunday   | <b>Full Rest</b>     |                                                                                                  |

## WEEKS 3-5: PROGRESSION

Load goes up. Distance goes up. This is where the work starts to feel real.

Week 3 the load jumps to 25 lb. You'll feel it. That's fine. The Zone 2 pace gets harder to maintain at higher load — if your heart rate spikes, slow down. Don't try to walk fast AND carry more weight at the same time in Week 3. Pick one adaptation at a time.

### Common mistakes in Weeks 3-5:

"Skipping the tempo ruck in Week 4 because it 'feels like enough' with the long ruck. The tempo ruck trains a different energy system. Don't skip it."

"Maxing out the heavy strength days when you're already taxed from the ruck. This is a hybrid program. The loads here are meant to challenge, not destroy. Leave one rep in the tank."

### Week 3

| Day       | Session                 | Details                                                                   |
|-----------|-------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Monday    | <b>Ruck — Zone 2</b>    | 3 miles @ 25 lb.                                                          |
| Tuesday   | <b>Strength A</b>       | 4×8 goblet squat, 4×8 RDL, 4×10 push-ups, 4×8 DB row, 3×40m farmer carry. |
| Wednesday | <b>Mobility + Light</b> | 10 min mobility. Optional: 20-min easy walk no load.                      |

| Day      | Session                  | Details                                                                                |
|----------|--------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Thursday | <b>Ruck — Zone 2</b>     | 3 miles @ 25 lb.                                                                       |
| Friday   | <b>Strength B</b>        | 4×8 trap bar deadlift, 4×8 OHP, 4×8 pull-ups, 4×15 KB swings, weighted carries.        |
| Saturday | <b>Tactical Finisher</b> | 4 rounds: 10 push-ups, 10 goblet squats, 10 KB swings, 10 step-ups weighted. Rest 90s. |
| Sunday   | <b>Full Rest</b>         |                                                                                        |

**40+ Modification:** If the jump from 20 to 25 lb on 3 miles is leaving your lower back tight, spend one more week at 20 lb and 2.5 miles before progressing. The progression is a guide, not a deadline.

#### Week 4

| Day       | Session                   | Details                                                                                                       |
|-----------|---------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Monday    | <b>Ruck — Long Zone 2</b> | 4 miles @ 25 lb. Slow and steady.                                                                             |
| Tuesday   | <b>Strength A</b>         | 4×8 goblet squat, 4×8 RDL (heavier), 4×10 weighted push-ups or dips, 4×8 row, 3×50m carry.                    |
| Wednesday | <b>Mobility + Rest</b>    | 10 min mobility.                                                                                              |
| Thursday  | <b>Ruck — Tempo</b>       | 2 miles @ 25 lb at brisk pace. Uncomfortable but sustainable. Should NOT be able to hold a full conversation. |
| Friday    | <b>Strength B</b>         | 4×6 trap bar deadlift (heavier), 4×8 OHP, 4×8 pull-ups, 3×15 KB swings.                                       |
| Saturday  | <b>Tactical Finisher</b>  | Sandbag complex — 5 rounds: 5 sandbag get-ups, 10 KB swings, 200m ruck run or fast walk. Rest 2 min.          |
| Sunday    | <b>Full Rest</b>          |                                                                                                               |

## Week 5

| Day       | Session                   | Details                                                                                                                                              |
|-----------|---------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Monday    | <b>Ruck — Long Zone 2</b> | 5 miles @ 30 lb. This is a real ruck. Fuel and hydrate properly.                                                                                     |
| Tuesday   | <b>Strength A</b>         | 4×8 goblet squat, 4×6 RDL (heavy), 4×10 push-ups, 4×8 row, 3×50m carries.                                                                            |
| Wednesday | <b>Mobility + Rest</b>    | 10 min mobility. This rest day matters — don't blow it.                                                                                              |
| Thursday  | <b>Ruck — Tempo</b>       | 2.5 miles @ 30 lb, brisk.                                                                                                                            |
| Friday    | <b>Strength B</b>         | 4×5 trap bar deadlift (working heavy), 4×8 OHP, 4×6 weighted pull-ups if available, 3×15 KB swings.                                                  |
| Saturday  | <b>Tactical Finisher</b>  | Kettlebell ruck circuit — 4 rounds: walk 400m with vest or ruck, carry kettlebell in one hand for 200m (switch arms), 10 goblet squats, 10 push-ups. |
| Sunday    | <b>Full Rest</b>          |                                                                                                                                                      |

**Recovery Check-in:** After 5 weeks, do a real inventory. How's your sleep? If you're under 7 hours average, the next three weeks will be harder than they need to be. Chapter 5 covers sleep and recovery. Read it now if you haven't.

## WEEKS 6-7: PEAK PHASE

"This is where you find out what you're made of. Not because it's supposed to crush you — but because the accumulated load of five weeks tells you exactly where your body is and what it can handle. Trust the process."

This is the hardest stretch of the program. Volume is high. Weight is up. The Zone 2 distances are real. Some days you won't want to go. Go anyway.

**The Show Up principle:** I was doing hill rucks one Thursday morning, nobody around, and I was yelling "Thursday! Thursday! Where is everybody?" — not because I was having a great time, but because the whole point is that you show up whether it's convenient or not. You want the results? Nobody's coming to make you. You do the work even when nobody's looking.

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## Week 6

| Day       | Session                       | Details                                                                                                        |
|-----------|-------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Monday    | <b>Ruck — Long Zone 2</b>     | 6 miles @ 35 lb. Start early. Take water.                                                                      |
| Tuesday   | <b>Strength A — 3×5 Heavy</b> | Trap bar deadlift 3×5 (work up to heavy set), goblet squat 3×5, OHP 3×5, farmer carry 3×50m.                   |
| Wednesday | <b>Mobility + Rest</b>        | Non-negotiable rest day this week. Full 10-min mobility routine.                                               |
| Thursday  | <b>VO2 Max — Hill Repeats</b> | 6× hill repeats under ruck (25-30 lb). Find a 200-300 yard incline. Walk up hard, walk down easy. Rest at top. |
| Friday    | <b>Strength B — Holds</b>     | 3×5 deadlift, 3×5 OHP, 3×8 weighted pull-ups, plank 3×60s, dead hang 3×30s.                                    |
| Saturday  | <b>Tactical Finisher</b>      | 5 rounds: 8 push-ups, 8 goblet squats, 8 KB swings, 200m run. Rest 90s. Preview of the Finisher.               |
| Sunday    | <b>Full Rest</b>              | Add 20-min walk only if you feel good. If not, don't.                                                          |

**40+ Modification:** If sleep has been rough or HRV is down, drop the hill repeats in Week 6 to 4 repeats and cap the long ruck at 5 miles. Better to arrive at Week 8 healthy than to peak in Week 6 and limp to the finish.

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## Week 7

| Day    | Session                   | Details |
|--------|---------------------------|---------|
| Monday | <b>Ruck — Long Zone 2</b> |         |

| Day       | Session                             | Details                                                                                                          |
|-----------|-------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|           |                                     | 7 miles @ 35-40 lb. Your longest training ruck. Take a buddy if you can.                                         |
| Tuesday   | Strength A — Heavy                  | 3×5 trap bar deadlift, 3×5 goblet squat (or barbell if available), 3×5 OHP, 3×50m weighted carry.                |
| Wednesday | Full Rest                           | Today is as important as Monday.                                                                                 |
| Thursday  | Ruck — Tempo                        | 3 miles @ 35 lb. Uncomfortable but moving.                                                                       |
| Friday    | Strength B                          | 3×5 deadlift, 3×8 weighted pull-ups or ring rows, 3×5 OHP, sandbag carries 3×30m.                                |
| Saturday  | Tactical Finisher — Dress Rehearsal | 8 rounds of 8 push-ups, 8 goblet squats, 8 KB swings. No ruck, just get the movement pattern locked in. Time it. |
| Sunday    | Full Rest                           |                                                                                                                  |

**Recovery Check-in:** Week 7 is the final push before taper. Rate energy, soreness, and sleep. If all three are good — you're ready. If energy is low and soreness is high — add an extra rest day between Saturday and Week 8. Your body does not lie.

## WEEK 8: THE FINISH

Monday through Thursday: de-load. Short, easy ruck at 20 lb (2 miles). Light strength work — 2 sets, moderate weight, nothing heavy. Let your body recover and sharpen. No new hard stimulus this week before Saturday.

| Day       | Session              | Details                                            |
|-----------|----------------------|----------------------------------------------------|
| Monday    | Ruck — Easy          | 2 miles @ 20 lb. Shake-out only.                   |
| Tuesday   | Strength — Light     | 2×8 of your main lifts. Nothing heavy. Move well.  |
| Wednesday | Rest                 | Sleep. Eat.                                        |
| Thursday  | Short Ruck           | 1.5 miles @ 20 lb. Last easy session.              |
| Friday    | Full Rest            | Prep your gear. Eat well at dinner. Sleep 8 hours. |
| Saturday  | Fit as Ruck Finisher | See Chapter 6.                                     |



| Day    | Session            | Details                                                             |
|--------|--------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Sunday | Reflection + Reset | Write your one-page reflection. Retest 3-mile ruck. Read Chapter 7. |

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# CHAPTER 5

## RECOVERY, SLEEP, AND NUTRITION

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If there's a chapter in this program that men over 40 skip, it's this one. Don't be that guy.

Now that I'm 53, I think recovery is extremely important. I like to do it in short, intentional bursts after I work out. Most of the time, I'll do a sauna session for about 30 minutes. I used to do contrast therapy after training too, meaning sauna plus a cold plunge, but I've come to feel like cold therapy works better for me before a workout. After I train, the sauna is what really helps me. It gets blood flowing, gives me that endorphin rush I need, helps calm me down, and lets my muscles settle into recovery mode. To me, that recovery window is where the real repair and rebuilding starts, especially over the next few hours after a workout. I think it's incredibly important, especially as you get older. If you can find a place like the YMCA or a recovery spot around town like Sweathouz, and they offer hot and cold therapy, it's absolutely worth looking into. Recovery is not extra to me. It's part of the work.

That last line is the whole thing. Recovery is not what you do when you're too sore to train. It's a training input. Program it like one.

### SLEEP

Seven hours is the floor. Not the goal. The floor.

Under 7 hours, your cortisol is elevated, your testosterone is suppressed, and your ability to repair muscle tissue is compromised. You also make worse decisions — about food, about training load, about everything. I know this because I've been on both sides of it. The version of me that slept 5 hours and drank too much and smoked cigarettes was not a high-performing person. The version of me 8 months into a real training regiment, sleeping 7-8 hours, is a different person.

This program is designed around a 40+ body. A 40+ body requires sleep the way a car requires oil. You can run it low for a while. But you will pay for it.

If your sleep is under 7 hours: don't add training, subtract it. Reduce intensity, keep the session, get to bed earlier. The training is not what makes you stronger. The recovery from training is what makes you stronger.

## **ALCOHOL**

I'm going to be straight about this: one beer on a Thursday night will wreck your Friday session at 42 in a way it did not at 22. That's not willpower, that's biology. Alcohol disrupts sleep architecture, suppresses HGH release during sleep, and creates an inflammatory state that your 40-year-old body takes 24+ hours to resolve.

I'm not telling you to never drink. I'm telling you to understand the trade-off. If Friday is a hard session, Thursday night is not the night to have drinks. Plan it. The guys who succeed with this program are the guys who treat alcohol like a scheduling decision, not a reflex.

## **PROTEIN**

Stuart Phillips' research puts the practical target at 1.6 g of protein per kg of bodyweight for men in a training program. Translated: 0.7-1.0 grams per pound of lean body mass daily.

If you weigh 200 pounds with roughly 20% body fat, your lean mass is around 160 pounds. Target is 130-160 grams of protein per day.

That sounds like a lot until you build meals around it: - 3 eggs at breakfast: 18g - 4 oz cottage cheese: 14g - 6 oz chicken breast at lunch: 42g - Greek yogurt as a snack: 15g - 6 oz ground beef at dinner: 42g - 1 scoop protein powder if needed: 25g

That's 156 grams without trying hard. The goal is consistent daily intake, not perfect tracking. Get in the range and stay there.

## CREATINE

Five grams per day. Every day. Whether you train or not.

Creatine monohydrate is the most studied supplement in sports science. It supports phosphocreatine regeneration (your short-burst energy system), supports cognitive function, and has shown benefit for muscle preservation in older athletes. It's cheap. It's safe. It has no meaningful side effects at 5g/day for most people.

I take it every morning with water. I have for years. If you're not taking it, start.

## MOBILITY — 10 MINUTES DAILY

Three areas. Do them every day, even rest days.

**Hips:** Hip flexor stretch (90/90 or kneeling lunge), hip circles, glute bridge with hold. Three minutes.

**T-spine (thoracic spine):** Thoracic rotation on hands and knees, foam roller T-spine extensions, seated rotation. Three minutes.

**Ankles:** Ankle circles, wall ankle stretch, heel raises. Two minutes.

That's it. Ten minutes. It takes longer to make coffee. There is no reason to skip this, and the difference it makes in how your body feels under load is not subtle.

After every ruck of 4+ miles, add foam rolling: quads, IT band, calves, lats. Don't skip the lats — ruck straps create tension there and most people don't notice until they can't raise their arms properly.

Recovery is not extra. It's part of the work.

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# CHAPTER 6

## THE FIT AS RUCK FINISHER: WEEK 8 CHALLENGE

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You've put in eight weeks. Now you prove it.

The Fit as Ruck Finisher is not a race. It's not a competition. It's a personal benchmark — a way to look at yourself in the mirror at the end of eight weeks and know, with data, that you did something. I designed it to be hard enough to feel like an accomplishment and specific enough that you can repeat it in six months to measure real progress.

### THE PROTOCOL

**Part 1: The Ruck** 8-mile ruck at 35 pounds. No time requirement — you finish it. Walk your own pace, stay in Zone 2 for the first 5 miles if you can, push the last 3 if you have it. Hydrate before you start. Bring water and a snack for mile 4-5. If you're doing it with a buddy — do it with a buddy. Jason and I have done long ruck hikes that started rough and ended with us both feeling better about everything. That's not a small thing.

**Part 2: The Strength Rounds** Immediately after completing the 8 miles (within 10-15 minutes of finishing, not the next day), complete:

**8 rounds of:** - 8 push-ups - 8 goblet squats (use whatever weight you've been training with — 35-44 lb) - 8 sandbag shoulders (right shoulder, then left = 1 rep each side, so 16 sandbag movements per round)

Rest 60-90 seconds between rounds. Do not rest more than 2 minutes. If you need to stop mid-round for form reasons, stop, reset, continue.

Total work: 64 push-ups, 64 goblet squats, 128 sandbag shoulder movements. Under load. After 8 miles.

That's the Finisher. Record your total time from the start of the ruck to the last sandbag shoulder.

## THE RETEST

After the Finisher — same day or the next day — run your 3-mile timed ruck at 20 lb. Same route if possible. Compare to your Week 2 baseline.

Most guys see a 4-8 minute improvement over 3 miles at 8 weeks. Some see more. The number matters less than the direction. If you're faster, you got fitter. Full stop.

## DOCUMENTATION

Take a photo. Write it down. I know some of you are going to roll your eyes at this, but here's why I'm asking: six months from now, you will want the receipt. The after-all-is-said-and-done mirror moment — where you count the wins — that's real. It hurt, you didn't always want to get up, you didn't always want to do the last session, but you look back down the road and everything paid off. That photo and that time and that reflection are evidence. Keep them.

One page. Write: 1. How you felt at the end of the 8 miles 2. Your time for the strength rounds 3. Your 3-mile retest time vs your Week 2 baseline 4. What surprised you about the program 5. What you want to do next

That's it. You don't need to post it anywhere. You just need to write it.

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# CHAPTER 7

## WHAT'S NEXT

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Finishing a program is easy to mismanage. You either stop everything and lose ground, or you immediately jump into the next thing at full intensity and get hurt. Don't do either.

The week after the Finisher is decompression. Easy rucks at 20-25 lb, 2-3 miles, nothing structured. Let your system reset. Sleep well. Eat well. Give yourself a week before you plan the next cycle.

After that week, you have a few paths:

**Maintenance:** Run Weeks 5-6 of this program on repeat with some variation in the tactical finishers. It's enough volume to maintain what you built without piling on more.

**Second cycle:** Start the program over at the beginning. You will not be starting where you started in Week 1. Your baseline is different now. The 20-pound ruck in Week 1 Round 2 will feel like nothing. That's the point. The next 8 weeks build on the engine you just built.

**Coaching:** I'm putting together a Fit as Ruck coaching cohort for men who want accountability, programming support, and a real community. It's a small group, Telegram-based, with a weekly Q&A. If that sounds like what you need, check the email you got after purchase — details will be there when it's ready.

**RuckTalk:** If you haven't listened to the podcast yet, that's where a lot of this material lives in longer form. Episodes on training, recovery, gear, the mental side of coming back in your 40s and 50s. Link in the email, or find it wherever you get podcasts. Jason and I have been doing this together and I can tell you: the conversations are worth the time.

The one thing I'll leave you with: you showed up. Somebody who doesn't care doesn't finish an 8-week program. The version of you that started Week 1 and the version of you that just crossed the Finisher are not the same person — not in the way that matters. Keep going.

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# APPENDIX

## A1 — ALL WORKOUTS AT A GLANCE

| Week | Mon                    | Tue              | Wed      | Thu                  | Fri              | Sat                | Sun                 |
|------|------------------------|------------------|----------|----------------------|------------------|--------------------|---------------------|
| 1    | Ruck Z2 2mi/<br>20#    | Str A            | Mobility | Ruck Z2 2mi/<br>20#  | Str B            | Tactical           | Rest                |
| 2    | Ruck Z2<br>2.5mi/20#   | Str A            | Mobility | Ruck Z2<br>2.5mi/20# | Str B            | Baseline Test      | Rest                |
| 3    | Ruck Z2 3mi/<br>25#    | Str A            | Mobility | Ruck Z2 3mi/<br>25#  | Str B            | Tactical           | Rest                |
| 4    | Ruck Z2 4mi/<br>25#    | Str A            | Mobility | Tempo 2mi/<br>25#    | Str B            | Tactical           | Rest                |
| 5    | Ruck Z2 5mi/<br>30#    | Str A            | Mobility | Tempo 2.5mi/<br>30#  | Str B            | Tactical           | Rest                |
| 6    | Ruck Z2 6mi/<br>35#    | Str A<br>(3×5)   | Rest     | Hill Repeats<br>6×   | Str B<br>(holds) | Tactical           | Rest                |
| 7    | Ruck Z2 7mi/<br>35-40# | Str A<br>(heavy) | Rest     | Tempo 3mi/<br>35#    | Str B            | Dress<br>Rehearsal | Rest                |
| 8    | Easy 2mi/20#           | Str Light        | Rest     | Short 1.5mi          | Rest             | <b>FINISHER</b>    | Retest +<br>Reflect |

## A2 — RUCK LOADING CHART

| Body Weight  | Week 1-2 | Week 3 | Week 4-5 | Week 6-7 | Finisher |
|--------------|----------|--------|----------|----------|----------|
| Under 160 lb | 15 lb    | 20 lb  | 25 lb    | 30-35 lb | 30 lb    |

| Body Weight | Week 1-2 | Week 3   | Week 4-5 | Week 6-7 | Finisher |
|-------------|----------|----------|----------|----------|----------|
| 160-200 lb  | 20 lb    | 25 lb    | 25-30 lb | 35-40 lb | 35 lb    |
| 200-230 lb  | 20 lb    | 25 lb    | 30 lb    | 35-40 lb | 35 lb    |
| Over 230 lb | 20 lb    | 25-30 lb | 30-35 lb | 40 lb    | 35-40 lb |

Note: These are starting points. If a load feels easy AND your form is solid AND your energy is good, you can add 5 lb earlier. If a load feels rough AND your lower back is talking to you AND sleep is off, back down 5 lb. Listen to your body. It's not lying to you.

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## A3 — ZONE 2 PACING GUIDE

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Zone 2 is where most of your ruck training should live — especially in Weeks 1-5 and during the long ruck days in Weeks 6-7.

**How to know you're in Zone 2:** - You can hold a full conversation (full sentences, not one-word answers) - Nasal breathing is sustainable — you're not gasping through your mouth - Heart rate is approximately 60-70% of your max HR (rough formula: 220 minus your age = max HR) - Example: 45-year-old = max HR ~175. Zone 2 = approximately 105-122 bpm. - If you have an HR monitor, use it. If not, the conversation test is reliable.

**Signs you've left Zone 2:** - You can only speak in short phrases - You're breathing through your mouth exclusively - Your HR is above 75% of max and climbing - You feel like you're racing

**What to do when you drift above Zone 2:** Slow down. That's it. There's no shame in slowing down — the whole point of Zone 2 work is to stay in it. A ruck where you're in Zone 3 half the time is not a Zone 2 session; it's a medium-intensity cardio session with some aerobic benefit. It's not bad, but it's not what the program is calling for on Zone 2 days.



**Practical pace guidance:** - Most men 40-55 will find their Zone 2 ruck pace is 16-21 minutes per mile under load in Weeks 1-3, tightening toward 14-18 minutes per mile by Weeks 6-7 as fitness improves. - On tempo ruck days, target 13-15 min/mile. Uncomfortable but not unsustainable. - Do not try to hold running pace under load. This is not a race.

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## A4 – PRINTABLE TRAINING LOGBOOK

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Print this page and keep it with your program. One row per session.

| Date | Session Type | Load | Distance/Sets | Duration | Sleep (hrs) | Energy (1-10) | Notes |
|------|--------------|------|---------------|----------|-------------|---------------|-------|
|      |              |      |               |          |             |               |       |
|      |              |      |               |          |             |               |       |
|      |              |      |               |          |             |               |       |
|      |              |      |               |          |             |               |       |
|      |              |      |               |          |             |               |       |
|      |              |      |               |          |             |               |       |
|      |              |      |               |          |             |               |       |
|      |              |      |               |          |             |               |       |
|      |              |      |               |          |             |               |       |

**Week 2 Baseline Ruck:** Time: \_ Date: \_

**Week 8 Retest Ruck:** Time: \_ Improvement: \_

**Fit as Ruck Finisher:** Date: \_ Total Time: \_

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Fit as Ruck is a product of Ground Rush Inc. Questions: [hello@fitasruck.com](mailto:hello@fitasruck.com) Podcast: RuckTalk — search wherever you listen 7-day refund policy — no questions asked

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